

What are Opinions? Integrating Theory and Methods for Automatically Analyzing Opinionated Communication (OPINION)

MINUTES OF THE MANAGEMENT COMMITTEE MEETING

COST ACTION CA21129 OPINION, 12 June 2024, University of Salamanca

Taken by Christian Baden (Chair)

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ACTION Status

- CSO approval: 27/05/2022
- Start date: 22/09/2022

1 ATTENDANCE

MC Members:

Edlira Gugu (AL), Anela Mulahmetovic Ibrisimovic (BA), Selma Veseljevic Jerkovic (BA), Tamara Kunic (HR), Dimitra Milioni (CY), Jaromir Mazak (CZ), Lenka Vochocova (CZ), Srdjan Vesic (FR), Emese Domahidi (DE), Christian Baden (IL, Chair), Larisa Mistrean (MD), Vuk Vukovic (ME), Damian Trilling (NL), Agnieszka Stepinska (PL), Agnieszka Hess (PL), Bruno Ferreira Costa (PT), Nicoleta Corbu (RO), Aleksandra Krstic (SR), Aleksandra Urman (CH), Tom Nicholls (UK, via Zoom)

Guests:

Nina Springer (Grant Coordination Officer), Elena Negrea Busuioc (Stakeholder Liaison Officer), David Herrero Blanco (Local Organizing Committee), Aysen Simsek (Grant Manager)

16 MC member countries represented:

Albania, Bosnia and Hercegovina, Croatia, Cyprus, Czechia, France, Germany, Moldova, Montenegro, Netherlands, Poland, Portugal, Romania, Serbia, Switzerland, United Kingdom.

18 MC member countries not represented:

Austria, Belgium, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, Greece, Hungary, Ireland, Israel, Italy, Lithuania, Luxembourg, North Macedonia, Norway, Slovenia, Spain, Sweden, Turkiye, Ukraine.

The quorum is thus *not* fulfilled. The MC meeting can deliberate, but not vote.

2 OBJECTIVES

The Objectives of the MCII.1 meeting are:

- Provide accountability of CG
- Discuss strategies for disseminating outcomes within and beyond the network
- Develop policy for future meetings
- Planning of meetings in GP3 and the rest of GP2

3 AGENDA

Welcome

Core Group Report to the MC

1. Membership
2. Activities & Emerging Issues

Planning & Network Policies

3. Updates to GP1 Work & Budget Plan/Draft of GP2 Work & Budget Plan
 - a. WG Meetings in Fall
 - b. Network Meeting in Winter
 - c. Further Meetings
 - d. Training School
 - e. Mobility & Grants
4. Publication Policy
5. Monitoring & Reporting to COST

Any Other Business

6. Summary of decisions & Closing

4 WELCOME

The MC welcomes Vuk Vukovic, who joins us for the first time in person as MC Member for Montenegro.

5 CORE GROUP ACTIVITY REPORT

Membership

OPINION presently has 201 members, and continues to receive about 3-4 applications every month.

We have gained representation in Ukraine, which means that the only countries that we are still not represented in are Iceland, Slovakia, Georgia, and Bulgaria. Diversity remains high overall, with many young, and a majority of female researchers, with some clusters especially in some ITCs, which we consider conducive to COST's mission of inclusion. The CG sees presently no reason to change our current admission procedures.

Activities & Emerging issues

The CG has organized the Limassol and Salamanca meetings, and supported WG4 in organizing the COpA Training School.

In terms of meeting attendance, visa emerge as an issue for on-site participation, especially for our Turkish membership. Partly, members don't obtain visa because we cannot furnish them with legal invitation letters (because OPINION is not a legal entity that can guarantee things; local hosts are not OPINION and therefore cannot be expected to guarantee on our behalf; and COST finds itself unable to help, despite our trying); and partly, they don't come because consulates don't offer timely appointments, or make it otherwise infeasible for them to apply. We may need to consider visa requirements as part of our meeting schedule.

OPINION's finances are overall healthy, also thanks to the added funding offered by COST; a technical problem is presented by COST's payment schedule, which requires us to spend a partial payment before requesting the next part (so our money, but not our budget, will run out one third into the reimbursement process for Salamanca). Aysen is already in contact with COST and we hope we can secure the next payment in time, so reimbursement can proceed without delays.

6 INTERNAL & EXTERNAL DISSEMINATION & STAKEHOLDERS

As the network evolves, all WGs, and many collaborative projects have started to create outputs that will be useful for others in the network, and need to be made relevant beyond the network, as well. There are several initiatives aimed at communicating results and creating impact:

- ◆ Ana Jovancevic and Edlira Gugu are initiating a series of Zoom talks (originally intended for WG4, but likely relevant for the entire network) where members of the network present research relevant to the network, on a monthly schedule. This is primarily intended as an internal dissemination event, although there are potentials for widening it beyond that.
- ◆ Emese Domahidi and Mario Haim are preparing a podcast series of conversations about and around OPINION's research agenda, addressing a Computational Social Science audience that extends well beyond the network.
- ◆ Elena Negrea Busuioc is proposing to initiate a webinar series wherein members of the network address specific topics of interest to selected stakeholder communities (e.g., pollsters, journalists, regulators, ...). To start designing such content, we need to identify inductions that we can make relevant to said stakeholder groups, and identify suitable speakers. Elena will be in contact with the WG leaderships about this

All of these initiatives require that there is a register of outcomes from the Action that the hosts of the respective initiatives, and the SCO, can draw upon to identify suitable speakers and themes. At present, Edlira's and Ana's initiative uses a Google sheet; we may need to think of a more sustainable means.

There appears to be presently no need to consider VNS resources to support these initiatives.

As a consequence of the decline of Twitter (now X), OPINION's current social media strategy is increasingly irrelevant, as fewer and fewer relevant audiences use the platform, and no one platform emerges to take its place. We will look into moving to LinkedIn to reach out to professional and stakeholder communities. For academic chatter, there seems to currently be no suitable substitute for X.

7 INTERNAL & EXTERNAL DISSEMINATION & STAKEHOLDERS

OPINION will host a Hackathon on September 23-24, in conjunction with the ECREA European Communication Conference in Ljubljana. The plan is to fund around 25-30 members participating in the event, and will open it to applications from beyond the network as much as there is space (after prioritizing network members' applications). The theme will be broad, so as to incentivize cross-disciplinary collaboration between computational scholars, social scientists and humanities researchers. Participants will be invited to pitch teams and approaches. The organizing committee, which will be chaired by Felicia Loecherbach, will include Carlos Arcila Calderon, Wouter van Atteveltdt, Aleksandar Tomasevic, Mariken van der Velden, and there were several additional members whose contribution to the organizing committee will still need to be defined.

8 FUTURE MEETINGS POLICY

We presently have three open invitations for future meetings:

- ◆ at the University of Elbasan, Albania, upon invitation by Edlira Gugu (this is already cleared and confirmed with the institution)
- ◆ at the University of Trabzon, Turkiye, upon invitation by Sule Özmen (pending confirmation)
- ◆ at the University of Zagreb, Croatia, upon invitation by Tamara Kunic (pending the re-instatement of a new dean, so this is not an option for the immediate future).
- ◆ At the meeting, there was also talk about the possibility of meeting at the University of Lisbon, upon invitation by Carlos Cunha (to be confirmed with the host)

Post Meeting, we received a fourth invitation:

- ◆ at the University of Lyon, France, upon invitation by Bruno Yun

For planning future meetings, several considerations must be made:

- ◆ We aim to cover a diversity of regions, to facilitate inclusion of different European communities of researchers; We have now been to the Netherlands, Prague, Limassol, and Salamanca, so areas yet to be covered include the Balkans and Central Mediterranean, the Baltic and Scandinavian Region, and the British/Irish Isles.
- ◆ Accessibility of locations is not only a matter of costs and convenience, but long transfers make attendance difficult for members who have other commitments adjacent to meeting days and can attend only if it is possible to

arrive or leave meeting venues quickly, and at any time of the day. It is desirable that meeting venues have international airports with many direct connections, as also relays extend travel time considerably (and are liable to faults).

- ◆ Visa requirements, especially for our Turkish members; there is a case for hosting a meeting in Turkiye, and/or a country that does not require visa for Turkish citizens (i.e., is not part of Schengen).
- ◆ During the meeting, also the issue of long air miles was brought up, so there is also an advantage to meeting in central locations to limit travel times and environmental impact.
- ◆ Also importantly, in Summer, we have the double event of the Joint WG Meeting and the COpA Training School, which requires more resources, but also permits us to possibly split the event between adjacent locations.

Regarding the Joint WG Meeting and COpA in Summer 2025, there is some consensus to take up Edlira's invitation to Elbasan. There are two variants to be considered: Doing both the Meeting and COpA in Elbasan (advantage: all is in one location, we have the invitation, things are fairly affordable; possible challenge: While transportation is manageable - ~45 min from Tirana airport, ~35 EUR for a taxi ride - there is no public transport connection, which may make attendance difficult for those who need to travel with narrow time frames); or doing COpA at Elbasan, together with a WG Meeting at the University of Tirana (which is easier to get to, and the capital may attract additional participants). The CG will look into both variants and decide. The tentative time range is in late May 2025.

Regarding the upcoming Joint WG Meeting in January/February 2025, there is no strong and clear tendency among the MC Members. Zagreb is not feasible in this time frame, Trabzon is again quite far away and requires relay flights from most origins, and Lisbon is very close to Salamanca (although Portugal is an ITC, which might justify the choice). A possibility might be to try and go to Istanbul, where OPINION has multiple member institutions. The CG will evaluate all options, including Lyon, which was brought up after the meeting, and if necessary, recruit additional options.

9 ANY OTHER BUSINESS

We will arrange an e-VOTE to confirm the upcoming change in the leadership of WG1, where Gabriella Szabo will follow Nicoleta Corbu as Vice Chair.